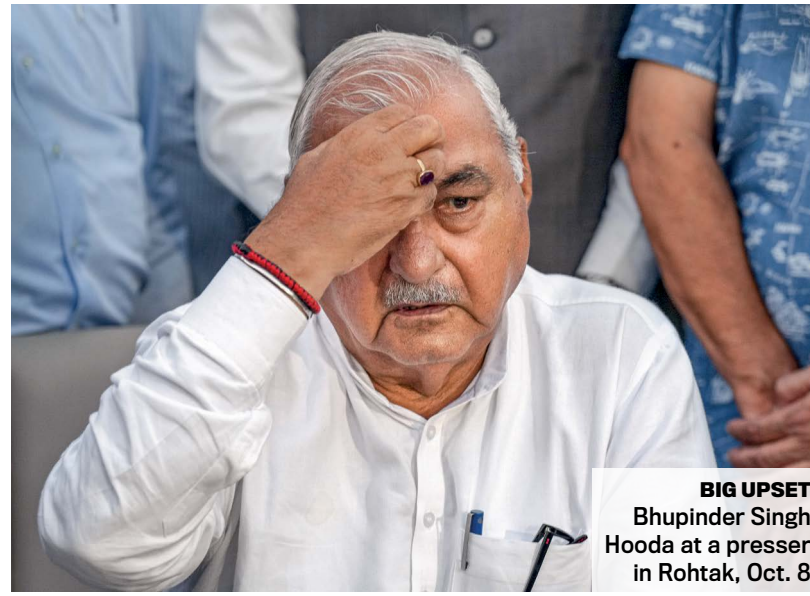
Rao won by a close margin. Thanks to the sweep in the region, Rao Inderjit is also staking a claim to the CM's post.

In the Lok Sabha poll, the BJP was done in by the Opposition narrative that the '*char sau paar* (400-plus)' target was intended at changing the Constitution and ending reservations for the backward communities, especially Dalits. With 17 reserved seats, any swing in the Dalit vote could have changed the outcome in 49 of the 90 assembly seats. Dalits make up 20.2 per cent of the voters in Haryana, but have never exhibited a set pattern of voting for any particular political party. This time, the infighting in the Congress between Dalit leader Kumari Selja and Jat leader Hooda helped considerably. The BJP managed to win eight seats—Nilokheri, Pataudi, Kharkhauda, Hodal, Bawal, Narwana, Israna and Bawani Khera—while the Congress won the other nine reserved seats.



PTI

BIG UPSET
Bhupinder Singh Hooda at a presser in Rohtak, Oct. 8

THE INFIGHTING IN THE CONGRESS BETWEEN DALIT LEADER KUMARI SELJA AND JAT LEADER HOODA HELPED THE BJP IN THE RESERVED SEATS

A BATTLE TEMPLATE

Other than the election win, what Haryana has given the BJP is a template its workers can refer to. The setbacks in J&K where the INDIA bloc swept the Valley also has pointers on how the BJP must engage with the Muslim community (see accompanying story *Now for the Hard Part*). Maharashtra, of course, is much bigger and more complex. What the victory in Haryana has done, BJP leaders say, is put the party in a better position to deal with aggressive allies there. Both the CM Eknath Shinde-led Shiv Sena and the Ajit Pawar-led Nationalist Congress Party were eyeing more seats in the belief that the LS results had diminished the BJP.

The RSS has already mobilised its swayamsevak base in Maharashtra and Jharkhand, and is organising division-level meetings between BJP and RSS leaders. In Maharashtra, it has formed several groups accommodating factions and leaders like Pankaja Munde, Vinod Tawade, Sudhir Mungantiwar and Chandrakant Patil. Even Union minister Nitin Gadkari is apparently in the loop in the plans for the assembly polls.

In the Lok Sabha election, the reservation issue had polarised the Dalits, tribals and Marathas and hurt the BJP, especially in regions like Marathwada. Party leaders say at least a section of the Hindu Dalits will return to the BJP fold as the *'char sau paar'* narrative will not operate in the assembly election. Like the experiment in Haryana, where it gained the non-Jat support, in Maharashtra, the BJP has revived its 'Madhav formula' (Malis, Dhangars and Vanjaris), the powerful OBC groups which it has been cultivating to challenge the political hegemony of the dominant Marathas. The loss in Haryana has also weakened the position of the Congress in the Maha Vikas Aghadi alliance (see Congress story *Lessons Not Learnt*), which should also work to the saffron camp's advantage.

Meanwhile, in Jharkhand, an excited BJP state president Babulal Marandi has already proclaimed, "*Kyon pade ho chakkar mein, Jharkhand mein koi nahin hai BJP ki takkar mein* (Why worry, there is no one in Jharkhand who can challenge the BJP)". The state has historically been a BJP stronghold but has of late been facing a major challenge: securing the Scheduled Tribe (ST) reserved constituencies, a weakness that cost them dearly in the 2019 assembly poll (it won only two of the 28 seats). In the May general election too, the party lost all five ST-reserved parliamentary seats even as it took the other nine in the state.

Recognising this weakness, the BJP has ramped up its outreach. PM Modi's visit to the state on October 2 saw the launch of the Rs 79,000 crore national 'Dharti Aaba Janjatiya Gram Utkarsh Abhiyan', designed to benefit over 50 million tribals nationwide. The BJP's main battleground in Jharkhand will be the Santhal Pargana region, a traditional JMM stronghold that has 18 of the 28 ST-reserved seats. The party is attempting to capture this base by raising the "Bangladeshi infiltrator" bogey against the Muslims, suggesting that outsiders are marrying tribal women and taking away local jobs and land.

In Jharkhand, the BJP also has to deal with four ex-CMs—Babulal Marandi, Arjun Munda, Madhu Koda and Champai Soren—and their aspirations. The RSS should be a big help in this; the experience in Haryana has taught the BJP that the Sangh makes it easier for the party to restore balance, not only among leaders but also within communities. It will be hoping that carries over in the coming elections too. ■

–*with* Dhaval S. Kulkarni and Amitabh Srivastava